

GLOSSARY

Aboriginals: the earliest known original inhabitants of a country; most often used to refer to the native peoples of Australia.

Acid rain: rain that has been polluted by gases from factories and traffic; when the rain falls it can damage crops, forests, and lakes.

Apartheid: the policy, developed in South Africa, of separating people according to their race.

Archipelago: a large group of islands

Arid: dry; with little rainfall.

Barren: lacking in vegetation; not able to produce fruit or crops.

Bauxite: the mineral ore from which aluminum is obtained.

By-product: a substance produced as a result of making something else.

Capitalism: an economic system based on private ownership of property, and on free and competitive conditions for business.

Cash crops: crops that are grown specifically to be sold for a profit.

Cattle ranch: a large farm where cattle are reared.

Civil war: a war between rival groups that live in the same country or region.

Collective farm: a farm owned and run by a group of people working together.

Colonize: to send a group of people to settle in another land and establish a colony.

Colony: a region or country that is controlled by another country; a group of people settled in a land outside their homeland, but still ruled by its laws.

Commercial farming: raising crops or animals for sale and profit.

Communism: an economic and political system in which farms and factories and the goods they produce are owned by the state.

Consumer goods: goods such as cars, computers, and televisions, purchased by people for personal use.

Cooperative farm: see Collective farm

Crude oil: petroleum in its natural state, before it has been treated in any way.

Culture: the values, beliefs, and way of life of the people of a country or region.

Deforestation: the large-scale clearing of healthy trees, often to make room for cash crops or for cattle ranching.

Delta: the flat area (often triangular in shape) formed by material deposited at the mouth of some rivers where they enter the sea or a large lake; deltas usually have highly fertile soil.

Democracy: a form of government based on the rule of the people, usually through representatives who have been voted into office by the people.

Dependency: a land run by another, usually more powerful, country.

Deposit: a natural grouping of minerals, such as oil or coal, within the Earth.

Dictatorship: a system of government where the ruler, or dictator, has absolute power.

Economy: the system by which a society manages its resources and makes and distributes goods and services.

Emigrant: a person who leaves his or her native country to settle in another.

Empire: a country and the conquered lands that it rules.

Environment: the natural world around us.

Ethnic group: a group of people sharing a common racial, religious, or cultural background.

Ethnic mix: the mix of ethnic groups in a country or region.

Export earnings: the money a country earns from selling goods or services to other countries.

Exports: goods or services sold to another country.

Extended family: a family that may include grandparents and other relatives as well as their children.

Favela: name used in Brazil for a shantytown.

Fertility, or birthrate: the average number of children born to a woman of childbearing age.

Fundamentalism: the belief that all the teachings of a particular religion must be strictly obeyed.

Guerilla: a member of a small military group fighting a stronger, official army, usually through surprise attacks.

Gulf: a large area of sea partly enclosed by land, such as the Persian Gulf or the Gulf of Mexico.

Hardwood: wood from broad-leaved trees, such as beech, oak, and mahogany.

Health care: medical services that diagnose and treat illness and provide care for pregnant women, the elderly, and disabled.

High-tech industries: industries that use or make the most recently invented and technologically advanced products, such as computers.

Hunter-gatherers: people who feed themselves by hunting wild animals and gathering fruits, nuts, and berries.

Hydroelectric power: electricity created by capturing the power of running water.

Immigrant: a person who has come from another country to settle.

Imports: goods or services bought from another country.

Indigenous people: the first, or native, people of an area or country.

Industry: economic activity that is concerned with manufacturing goods or processing raw materials.

Investment: the provision of resources, usually money, for a business venture, with the goal of later making a profit from it.

Irrigation: supplying dry land with water through a system of canals or pipes so that crops will grow.

Landlocked: surrounded by land; with no access to the sea.

Latin America: those parts of the American continent where the official language is Spanish or Portuguese; often used to mean Mexico and Central and South America.

Life expectancy: the average number of years a person can expect to live.

Literacy rate: the percentage of people over the age of 15 who can read and write a simple sentence.